Research report

THE CFO GROWTH CODE

THE 4 HABITS OF HIGH-PERFORMING CFOS

Sage

High-Performance
Finance Software

POWERED BY Ai

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Introduction

Is AI your constant copilot for finance tasks? Does data underpin all your decisions? Do you influence the whole business, not just your team? Are you on top of compliance?

If the answer to any of these is “no”, you are falling behind your peers.

This is the bottom line of new global research from Sage, which identifies a group of trailblazing finance leaders who are powering growth for their companies.

This group, dubbed the high-performance finance leaders, is laser-focused on 4 constructive, forward-looking behaviors:

1. Maximizing their use of **AI** and **automation**, allowing them to refocus on strategy
2. Harnessing workforce **data** to drive sharper thinking and stronger business results
3. Extending their **influence** beyond finance to a wider internal and external audience
4. Getting on top of **compliance** issues to bypass potential future pain points

The research shows that this combination of behaviors has a powerful effect on the way a CFO leads.

A third (33%) of companies represented by high-performance finance leaders saw strong revenue growth in the past year, compared with only 17% of those who manage finance in a more traditional manner—we call these the legacy finance leaders. This suggests that companies are twice as likely to supercharge their growth if they adopt these 4 habits.

And the research shows that these behaviors are not just nice to have—they’re essential. Failure to keep up does not just mean you stand still. You fall further and further behind. Legacy finance leaders are more than twice as likely as high-performance finance leaders to see revenue slump (8% vs. 3%). Which group would you rather be in? It’s a no-brainer.

In this report, we explore what it means to be a high-performance leader and recommend steps to get you there.

Habit 1:

LEVERAGE AI AND AUTOMATION WHEREVER POSSIBLE

AI is a powerful productivity tool enabling high-performance finance leaders to grow. How can you get it to do the same for you?

1. Bring the power of technology to finance

AI success needs solid technology foundations. Most finance leaders have these in place, both within the finance department and the wider business. Whether boosting cost efficiencies (84%), automating the business (79%), or making sure data drives decision-making (83%), technology leaders have high hopes that technology can make everything bolder and better.

One company that has developed its whole business around technology is AlphaSense. Its AI-based platform synthesizes a wide range of market intelligence—including company filings, earnings transcripts, expert insights, research reports, and news—empowering professionals across industries to save significant time and make better decisions. The tech-first culture at the company extends to the finance department, which also uses the technology extensively.

"We've implemented predictive models to analyze churn, understand customer retention, and refine acquisition strategies," explains CFO Joe HIll. "Using AI helps us understand who's happy, why customers leave, and how to respond. It allows us to be forward-looking and not bogged down by manual processes."

Michael Ryall, CFO at property development company Spyre, agrees that technology is at the core of his business too.

"Everything we do is tech-driven, which is so different from when I started," he says. "Then, the role was about understanding information and presenting what had happened in the past. Now, technology has evolved to be forward-looking, with the next 5 years set to be even more exciting."

High-performance finance leaders take all the help they can get from automation and AI

High-performance finance leaders use AI every day and to a much greater extent than legacy finance leaders. An overwhelming **96%** of high-performance finance leaders say AI underpins their daily finance processes, and they're not stopping there—almost all (93%) of them expect to increase their use of AI in the next 2 years.

2. Put AI at the center of working life

Generative AI is one of the hottest trends at the moment, and it's easy to see why. Its fast, detailed, and accurate summaries and creations help professionals save time and develop new ideas. No wonder that the market size for this technology alone is set to skyrocket. Gartner expects worldwide generative AI spend to reach $644 billion in 2025, up 76% from 2024[1].

Our research shows that AI tools are already becoming an important part of finance leaders' lives. Some 65% use ChatGPT at least once a month, with similar numbers adopting Microsoft Copilot (59%) and Google Gemini (57%) at the same frequency.

But beyond day-to-day AI assistants, finance leaders have yet to fully explore the technology's potential. Only 42% use AI-powered finance tools on a monthly basis or more.

AI has the power to completely transform the finance department, according to Aaron Harris, CTO of Sage.

"Everyday AI tools like ChatGPT are just the tip of the iceberg," he says, "CFOs who think AI begins and ends with basic chat interfaces are missing the real transformation. What's coming next will fundamentally reshape how finance functions operate.

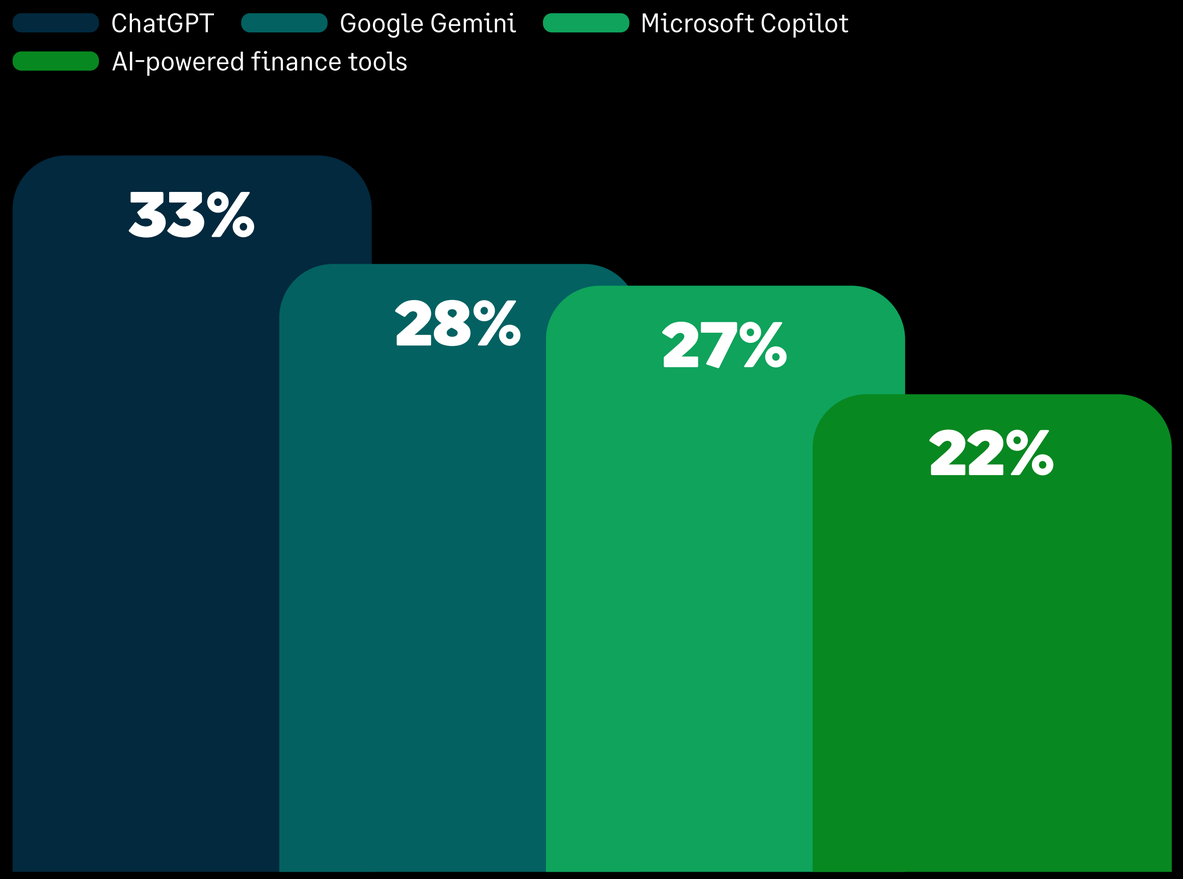
"This isn't about being a bit faster here or sparking a clever idea there—AI is enabling a complete rethink of how work gets done in finance. We're talking about autonomous systems that manage entire workflows end-to-end, not just assist with tasks.

"For instance, invoice processing today might involve AI matching line items to purchase orders. But an autonomous AI agent can go further, flagging discrepancies, contacting vendors for corrections, and continuously improving its accuracy over time. That's not assistance; that's intelligent delegation. And it will free CFOs to focus on foresight, not just oversight."

Everyone can benefit from better data, but AI and finance go hand in hand.

The technologies finance leaders use every day

Do you use the following technologies every day in your current role?



1 https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2025-03-31-gartner-forecasts-worldwide-genai-spending-to-reach-644-billion-in-2025

72% **of senior finance leaders believe they're not using AI to its full potential.**

"AI can take unstructured, qualitative information in different formats and structure it in the right way for analysis, and then even do some of the analysis itself," adds David Yates, CFO of software company Gresham. "This saves so much time and, quite simply, we would never have the human capacity to do that work."

Yates notes that AI can also unearth critical hidden information. "We have an FP&A platform in place that can group transactions together and give us an initial view of trendlines. AI can flag churn risks if customers display the same behaviors as others who have left in the past."

3. Ride the AI innovation wave

We are still only at the very tip of the iceberg in terms of what AI can do. Finance leaders should make a habit of keeping up with developments and use cases, ready to pounce on anything that could improve performance.

With around 83% of finance leaders expecting to maintain or increase their use of AI-powered finance tools in the next 2 years, it's safe to say that CFOs have AI firmly on their radars.

Our research showed that 72% of senior finance leaders believe they're not using AI to its full potential. Given that 86% view the use of AI as critical to remaining competitive, it's imperative that they align themselves with AI experts who can support them in their daily work.

Embracing AI in this way will be rewarded with significant time and money savings in the future. But failing to act could have a cost that's not worth thinking about.

At Metro Finance in Australia, AI-powered technologies are transformative.

"We have a robot that is dedicated to the finance team," explains CFO Mark Donovan. "It does a lot of data transformation, and then using that data, it posts journals into our ERP system on a regular basis. It means we can enable our staff to do more value-add activities like engaging with people and understanding different drivers across the business.

"AI is doing this mundane, routine sort of tasks that are ripe to be automated by a robot. There's a lot of efficiency gains we've managed to achieve here."

Embracing agentic AI—the next frontier for AI

AI agents are at the cutting-edge of AI development today. Building on the transformative efficiency of traditional AI, agentic AI offers an additional edge: the power to take action.

For instance, a traditional AI chatbot might answer questions using predefined scripts and responses. But agentic AI can respond more naturally and take appropriate actions, such as transferring users to the right team or resolving matters directly.

This is what's happening at Palo Alto Networks, which has rolled out AI agents to respond to the hybrid working world[2].

Its HR agent, Sheldon, "speaks" to employees in a conversational manner and gives meaningful, human-like responses. It also autonomously evaluates requests and uses its own judgment to act.

"Agentic AI is a game-changer for finance," says Sage's CTO Harris. "We're not talking about simple task automation anymore; we're talking about AI that can take ownership of entire processes like vendor payments or monthly close while keeping humans in the loop to manage exceptions and make critical decisions.

"CFOs must be exploring this now. AI agents reduce manual workloads, free up staff to focus on strategic initiatives, and provide real-time insights that sharpen decision-making. At Sage, we've already seen early success with Sage Copilot, where companies like Greenidge cut their monthly close time by 33% through AI-enabled automation."

"Getting started doesn't require a moonshot. Finance leaders should identify bottlenecks like invoice matching or reconciliations and run small, controlled pilots using accessible agentic tools. The key is building internal confidence and ensuring the AI is grounded in domain-specific models that understand accounting's regulatory and operational complexity."

2 https://www.moveworks.com/us/en/resources/blog/agentic-ai-examples-use-cases

Practical steps to maximize your use of AI and automation

Sage executive vice president Caroline Xu, commercial finance, explains that bringing AI into the finance department can be easier than you might expect.

"The best advice I have for CFOs is to start small," she says. "It's not about the big bang that's going to change the way finance operates overnight; it's more about driving that continuous innovation mindset and looking for the incremental improvements that can be made over time.

"A good way to start is by looking at one existing process and assessing it using an impact-versus-effort matrix to see where you can maximize the potential of AI. Then, see what can be done to reduce the manual elements of the process.

"Innovation doesn't have to be perfectly designed before it gets deployed. Experiment and make bold decisions, and then use the results to help inform how we can refine the automation over time."

“Using AI helps us understand who’s happy, why customers leave, and how to respond. It allows us to be forward-looking and not bogged down by manual processes.”

Joe Hill
CFO, AlphaSense

Habit 2:

MAKE DATA-DRIVEN DECISIONS ALWAYS

High-performance finance leaders immerse themselves in data

Data is always part of high-performance finance leaders' thinking. Some **44%** of them use data or process automation at least once a week, **65%** leverage data visualization at the same frequency, and **61%** use outlier detection tools.

And they're not just using data more—they're getting better results from it. Unsurprisingly, high-performance finance leaders are much more likely than legacy finance leaders to expect these technologies to have a positive impact on the finance function over the next 2 years.

"It's essential that our data is joined up in this way to give customers the level of personalization that they would expect."

Martin Miles
CFO, British Heart Foundation

High-Performance leaders recognize that data is the lifeblood of enhanced performance. How can you use your data to get ahead?

1. Use data to drive better customer outcomes

CFOs and finance leaders are desperate to take control of the headwinds buffeting their businesses. As many as 83% want greater visibility of financial and operational data to help them inform business decisions.

The British Heart Foundation (BHF) is undertaking a major data-led program to modernize its key technologies, with an underlying focus on improving customer experience. Through fundraising activities and its network of 665 shops across the UK, the charity generates millions of pounds annually for research into heart and circulatory diseases. Whether a donation of cash or stock, it's essential that the BHF makes giving as easy as possible.

"We recognize that we need to engage with our customers in a more holistic way," explains CFO Martin Miles. "You might be a shop customer of BHF, or a supporter, or you donate stock to us, or perhaps you're a heart patient asking for advice—or likely more than one of these. We need to know you're the same person, however you choose to engage with us.

"It's essential that our data is joined up in this way to give customers the level of personalization that they would expect. They need the same experience they get from the large tech companies they're used to working with."

2. Use data to transform your own role

Companies today are rich in data, and CFOs must use this to their advantage. Intelligence and insights are valuable currency within companies, especially those that are digitally transforming. But without a leader to make sense of them, they're meaningless.

This is where the CFO comes in, according to AlphaSense's CFO Joe Hill.

"The CFO isn't just a steward of the balance sheet anymore," he says. "We've become growth architects and commercial catalysts, all thanks to data."

He adds that CFOs should apply their analytical mindsets not just to the balance sheet but also to the wealth of data that flows through the business today.

Practical steps to put data behind every decision

Sage's Caroline Xu emphasizes that companies must look at the big picture to fully understand and improve their data strategy.

"It's essential to take stock of the current situation first," she says. "Think about the systems landscape through which you operate, and the data sources that are created as a result, and what is currently being used where.

"This gives a good sense of what the big areas of improvement could be. It helps you to navigate the systems or tools that are not being used in the right way and gives you a sense of what can be improved to help you make data-led decisions.

"Finally, assessing your systems landscape in this way helps you to evaluate how you can integrate systems as part of your wider digital transformation, which is essential to unlocking rich and valuable data."

Habit 3:

EXPAND YOUR INFLUENCE

High-performance finance leaders are expanding their networks

Over the past 2 years, **high-performance finance leaders** have been more likely than legacy finance leaders to broaden their sphere of influence, taking on a range of non-finance tasks, including operations, profitable growth initiatives, and workforce planning.

And, over the next 2 years, they expect this trend to accelerate. **Over a third (34%)** expect to be solely responsible for ESG, **38%** think digital transformation will fall to them, and **31%** expect to take charge of building company culture.

around

65%

of finance leaders say it's difficult to balance the evolving needs and priorities of stakeholders.

As CFO, you need to break out of finance and get your hands dirty in other areas of the business. But how can you do it?

1. Evolve or risk irrelevance

Gone are the days when finance leaders kept the company books and revenue charts up to date, and that was it. Today, 90% of all finance leaders say that they're working in and influencing areas of the business that, a year ago, they would have considered beyond their remit.

Today, they're responsible—either jointly or solely—for areas such as company culture (64%), digital transformation (69%), and operations (68%). Some are even shaping the DEI agenda (63%) and sustainability and ESG reporting (67%).

This isn't an easy change to make. Around 65% of finance leaders say it's difficult to balance the evolving needs and priorities of stakeholders.

2. Prove your value in new ways

David Yates at Gresham explains that new tech and offshoring options mean that finance professionals are under pressure to deliver more business value than ever.

"No one really wants to spend money on a finance person if all they are going to do is present some monthly numbers and then retreat to a back room," he says.

"People expect finance to add more value by being able to look around corners, flag up problems or, if there's an opportunity to leap on, or pricing they need to look at."

BHF's Martin Miles agrees. Looking back at his professional history, he acknowledges that his role has evolved significantly. Now, he feels he can delegate day-to-day finance responsibilities among his team, freeing him up to play a more strategic role in the charity.

"I chair our operations board, which sits below the executive board and looks at things like policy, risk, portfolio, and change management," he explains. "I jointly sponsor projects around resilience, retail logistics, and technology change. With a finance mindset and a commercial background, I can add value to these initiatives."

David Yates adds that he has recently added significant value by working on his company's merger with cloud solutions provider Alveo.

"There was a lot of restructuring, integrating new people, bringing teams together, and looking at costs and infrastructure. I ran all these processes alongside my finance role," he explains.

3. Become part of a new work ecosystem

As their influence expands, finance leaders will find they develop a stimulatingly diverse new peer group.

Jeff Whaley, CFO of Haversine Funding, says that in a data-driven world, peers in the C-suite rely on them more than ever.

"It's one thing for a CEO to go on an investor call and simply say, 'we had a great year,' and leave it at that. But it's another thing to say, 'we had a great year because revenue grew by X amount,'" he explains.

"Why did it grow? Because we performed better in a specific area. Our spreads increased in one space, while they decreased in another. And all of that comes back to data. If you're going to support your decisions and speak with authority, you need data. And typically, that means it all comes back to the CFO."

CFOs are also forging closer relationships with CEOs and the board, making their mark among senior leaders by shaping the strategy that will grow the business.

This could ultimately pave the way for them to assume top roles themselves, as 90% of finance professionals have ambitions to be CEO. Becoming a familiar, valued, and trusted figure at the top table, with a clear view and understanding of the whole company, puts them in great shape.

These transitions are not just theoretical, either. In September 2024, Edinburgh-based global investment firm Aberdeen appointed Jason Windsor as CEO. He had joined the firm as CFO, following a long career in the role[3]. And ClearBank announced in March 2025 that Mark Fairless would move up from finance leader to become CEO. The board said that, as CFO, Fairless had been instrumental in forming the long-term strategy[4].

Practical steps to take today to expand your influence

Caroline Xu of Sage says CFOs must be proactive when building their network.

“If you don’t yet have a seat at the table in key forums, ask for one,” she says. “Don’t let finance be an afterthought in key decision-making, and where appropriate, get in on these processes early on so that you can better influence before decisions are made.

“Make sure you explain why you want to be involved and try to explain your story clearly to non-finance audiences. Bring them on the journey with you; it makes it much easier for them to understand your goals in working with them when they understand how it helps the company achieve its overall objectives.”

3 https://www.aberdeenplc.com/en-gb/about-us/our-leadership-team/jason-windsor
4 https://clear.bank/learn/news/clearbank-appoints-new-ceo

Habit 4:

TAKE COMMAND OF COMPLIANCE

High-performance finance leaders are in control of compliance

High-performance finance leaders are not cowed by compliance: **90%** of them find it easy, compared with only **74%** of legacy finance leaders.

Why? Because they're more likely to take ownership of compliance issues. **The majority (51%)** of high-performance finance leaders take sole responsibility for compliance, compared with only **39%** of legacy finance leaders.

By taking the compliance bull by the horns, assertive CFOs can wrestle it to the ground—and keep it there. But this requires some personal courage and resources. How do you find what you need?

1. Take compliance seriously

"Our reputation is built on compliance," says BHF's Martin Miles, underscoring its importance in the finance department.

But in a fast-changing environment, it's not always easy. In the UK, the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill is due to come into force in 2025. The bill is intended to strengthen and protect essential digital services. In the US, the new Trump administration's wave of executive orders is reshaping compliance expectations across the board.

It's simply not an issue that finance leaders can overlook. CFOs must carefully balance automation, new regulations, and overall compliance.

Sage's Harris says in today's AI-first world, compliance is more important than ever.

"In today's AI-first world, compliance isn't just important—it's foundational," he says "AI is advancing rapidly, but in finance, speed without accuracy is dangerous. The smartest AI in the world won't protect you if it doesn't understand the regulatory frameworks you operate in.

"Off-the-shelf AI models may be powerful, but they weren't built for finance. That's why at Sage, we're investing in domain-specific LLMs tailored to accounting standards and compliance obligations. It's the only way to build AI agents you can trust to operate in high-stakes, regulated environments like finance.

"For CFOs, compliance can't be an afterthought or a separate workstream. It must be built into every phase of AI development and implementation. The best finance leaders I see are already embedding compliance teams into their AI projects—not as gatekeepers, but as copilots ensuring the solutions they build today stand up to scrutiny tomorrow."

“In today’s AI-first world, compliance isn’t just important—it’s foundational.”

Aaron Harris
CTO, Sage

2. Collaborate for compliance success

To get to grips with compliance, collaboration across departments is essential. At BHF, CFO Miles works closely with the legal team to achieve compliance goals.

“Compliance is all about having good, capable people around you,” he says. “In areas like GDPR, for example, we will reach out. We’ve got a great in-house resource, but because of the scale of the challenge, we often seek professional external advice.”

Gresham’s Yates also places collaboration at the heart of the compliance agenda. He points to the recent Digital Operations Resilience Act, an EU regulation to ensure financial services firms are resilient to the repercussions of cyberattacks. Again, finance and legal teams work closely together to ensure the company can withstand threats from hostile actors and demonstrate that they have taken steps to protect sensitive information.

“Support comes from multiple places,” he says. “It’s essential to understand where the regulation is going to come from and how it will affect you. You should never assume you know the answers.”

Practical steps to navigate compliance with ease

Caroline Xu of Sage says it’s essential to build a compliance-based culture, even during times of rapid transformation.

“The role of the CFO and the finance function is evolving quickly in many organizations, but it is essential that we don’t compromise on compliance,” she explains. “It is essential that we get our numbers right, as this is a critical component of our integrity as a finance function. Compliance has a hugely important role here and cannot be overlooked.

“In a world of AI and automation, compliance provides trust to our stakeholders, both internal and external.”

Conclusion:

THE FUTURE IS HIGH-PERFORMANCE

The data is clear: high-performance finance leaders supercharge growth, thanks to their laser focus on the following areas:

- Maximizing their use of AI and automation, allowing them to refocus on strategy
- Harnessing workforce data to drive sharper thinking and stronger business results
- Extending their influence beyond finance to a wider internal and external audience
- Getting on top of compliance issues to bypass potential future pain points

For any company, tackling these 4 areas can be hard work, and for small and medium-sized businesses, it can be even harder.

But Sage is here to help. Our products, services, tools, and support are built with you in mind, enabling you to emulate the success of high-performance finance leaders and drive your growth.

Find out more about how we can help you today.

We know that CFOs and finance leaders want to be strategic assets to their companies. Demonstrating these behaviors will make them just that. The future of the finance department is not coming—it's already here, and it's High Performance.

33% VS 17%

A third (33%) of high-performance companies saw strong revenue growth in the past year, compared with only 17% of the rest.

About the research

Sage surveyed 1,707 finance leaders from the US, UK, Canada, France, Germany, South Africa, Spain, and Australia. Respondents represented companies with employees between 20 and 499 in the following industries: software-as-a-service and software, not-for-profit, professional services, healthcare, financial services, hospitality, construction and real estate, distribution and manufacturing, insurance, and education. Some 20% were CFOs, with the rest being senior finance leaders.

High-performance finance leaders exhibit the following traits:

AI and automation

Maximize their use of AI and automation, allowing them to refocus on strategy

Data

Harness workforce data to drive sharper thinking and stronger business results

Influence

Extend their influence beyond finance to a wider internal and external audience

Compliance

Get on top of compliance issues to bypass potential future pain points

These companies represented 20% of the overall sample (346 respondents). Legacy finance leaders constitute the rest of the sample that does not fall into the high-performance finance leader group.

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